

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 243

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1961

Coverage Date: 1950-1961

Place Coverage: Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana

Section Title(S): 7 Reserved Behavior

7 Reserved Behavior

As I described in Chapter 6, the !Kung avoid sexually tinged joking with certain categories of relatives and name-relatives. A number of additional avoidances are also practiced with persons who fall into these categories of relationship, and respectful modes of address are used with them. With a few exceptions (mostly for children), these avoidances exactly parallel the joking relationship—if a person avoids joking with another he also practices the other avoidances with him and uses respectful modes of address. Taken all together, the avoidance of joking, the additional avoidances, and the use of respectful modes of address form one large complex of behavior that I call “reserved behavior.”¹ The !Kung standards of modesty also seem to me to belong to this complex.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

576
[Etiquette](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

The demands of reserved behavior are mild, moderate, and practical in all cases. No exaggerated action or excessive inconvenience is required. Essentially, I believe, reserved behavior is a set of conventions that act in a formal, almost token way to demonstrate constraint. Reserved behavior requires, for example, that people keep at a distance from each other, avoid joking with each other, and avoid addressing each other by name. The conventional behavior is the opposite of intimate. I believe its purpose is to manifest and reinforce in everyday life the sexual constraints imposed by the !Kung belief in the extended incest taboo. Moderate as these demands are, they are taken seriously by the !Kung and are rarely disregarded, so far as I know. The !Kung say they fear to joke with someone they should not joke with. They fear also to disregard the other avoidances, although they say that should they do [■ 244](#) so no punishment would be inflicted by the gods, the forces of nature, or society. “Nothing would happen,” they say—except that

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

626
[Social Control](#)

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

835
[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

they would incur the disapproval of the group: "People would laugh." Group approval is a powerful sanction to the !Kung. They need approval and want it, and to win it they readily conform to the proprieties.

1. Some remarks on polite behavior as distinct from reserved behavior are to be found in Chapter 9.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)